saw that if the Sultan escaped to the women's apartments, it would be difficult to consummate the plot." He ran after Qutb-ud-Din, grabbed him by the hair, and pulled him down. The two men were still wrestling on the ground when the other conspirators arrived behind him. As Khusru bellowed at them to be careful, one of them speared the sultan and dragged him off.[8]

Qutb-ud-Din's headless, dismembered body was thrown into the courtyard. Khusru Khan and his men carried out a palace purge, murdering all of the sultan's supporters. Then, at midnight, all of the remaining officials assembled in the courtyard by torchlight and recognized Khusru as the new sultan. "Khusru Khan had prevailed," writes Barani, "the face of the world assumed a new complexion, a new order of things sprung up, and the basis of the dynasty of 'Ala'-ud-Din was utterly razed."[9]

KHUSRU KHAN'S SULTANATE lasted a single year.

Barani's distaste aside, he seems to have been a reasonably competent ruler and soldier, and the sultanate itself, tightly organized by 'Ala'-ud-Din, continued to run more or less smoothly. But as soon as he was secure on his new throne, Khusru Khan renounced his profession of Islam and returned to Hindu practice. The conquered Hindus rejoiced, especially when Khusru began to promote Hindu officers and courtiers through the ranks. But the coherence of the Delhi sultanate was largely due to 'Ala'-ud-Din's vision of the empire as an Islamic realm, bringer of truth to the heathens, and Khusru Khan's reconversion quickly wiped out his support. Barani complains that "preparations were made for idol worship in the palace" itself, and that "copies of the Holy Book were used as seats, and idols were set up in the pulpits"; it is unlikely that Khusru was foolish enough to defy Islamic practice so overtly, but Barani's chronicle reflects the outrage that the Muslims of Delhi felt over this reversal.[10]

Two months after Khusru's accession, the governor of one of the outlying areas in the Punjab, Ghazi Malik Tughluq, rallied an opposition party against him. In a pitched battle outside the walls of Delhi, a collection of Muslim governors and their troops faced down Khusru's royal army. The sultan's force broke and ran; Khusru himself hid in a nearby garden, where he was discovered and beheaded on the spot.

The governors then proclaimed Ghazi Malik the next sultan ("You have delivered us from the yoke of the Hindus!" they exclaimed). He took the royal title Sultan Ghiyas-ud-Din, and, Barani concludes, "everyone paid him due homage. . . . In the course of one week, the business of the State was brought into order, and the disorders and evils occasioned by Khusru and his unholy followers were remedied." Two Delhi dynasties had fallen, and now a third